



Life After School

Navigating the Transition Cliff — From Age 18 to Adult Life

Knowledge is power. Partnership is progress. Together — the IEP gets APPROVED.

What Is the Transition Cliff?

For 18+ years, your child's education — and often their services, structure, social connections, and daily purpose — has been provided by the school system. Then, at age 21 (or upon graduation), IDEA eligibility ends. Overnight, the structured world of special education disappears.

This is the Transition Cliff. Families who plan for it land safely on the other side. Families who don't often face a crisis. This guide helps you prepare — ideally years before the cliff arrives.

What Ends at Age 21

- IDEA eligibility and all IEP services
- Free appropriate public education (FAPE)
- The legal right to an IEP team and annual meetings
- School-based speech, OT, PT, and counseling services
- Transportation provided by the school
- The structured daily schedule school provides
- Automatic connection to peers and social community

What Continues and What's Available

Vocational Rehabilitation (VR)

State agencies that fund job training, college support, assistive technology, and supported employment. Connect before age 21 — ideally at 16. VR can pay for college, certification programs, and job coaching.

■ *How to access: rsa.ed.gov/about/states*

Medicaid / Medicaid Waiver

Most young adults with significant disabilities qualify for Medicaid. Waiver programs fund home and community-based services including personal care, day programs, and supported living. Waitlists can be YEARS long — apply early.

■ *How to access: Your state Medicaid office*



SSI / SSDI

Supplemental Security Income (SSI) provides monthly income for adults with disabilities who have limited income and resources. Apply at age 18 — do not wait. SSDI is for those with work history.

■ *How to access: ssa.gov*

Developmental Disabilities (DD) Agency

State agencies that fund adult services for people with developmental disabilities. Services vary by state and include residential support, day programs, and employment services. Apply early — waitlists are long.

■ *How to access: Your state DD agency*

College Disability Services

If your young adult attends college, disability services offices provide accommodations under ADA and Section 504. They do not provide an IEP — accommodations must be requested and self-advocated.

■ *How to access: Contact the college directly*

Supported Employment Programs

Job coaches, workplace supports, and competitive integrated employment programs. Often funded through VR or DD agency. Ask specifically about "customized employment" for those with significant support needs.

■ *How to access: Through VR or DD agency*

Independent Living Centers (ILCs)

Nonprofit organizations in most states that help people with disabilities live independently. Services include peer support, life skills training, housing assistance, and benefits counseling.

■ *How to access: ilru.org to find your local ILC*

Legal Considerations at Age 18

When your child turns 18, they become a legal adult — regardless of disability. This has significant implications:

IDEA rights transfer: At 18, IDEA rights transfer from parents to the student. The student must be notified and given a copy of Procedural Safeguards. Schools must get consent from the student (not the parent) for evaluations and placements.

Guardianship: If your young adult cannot make informed decisions independently, you may need to seek legal guardianship through the courts. This is expensive and removes civil rights — consider carefully.



Supported Decision-Making: An alternative to guardianship where trusted people help the individual make their own decisions without taking legal control. Many states now recognize Supported Decision-Making agreements. Recommended over guardianship when possible.

Healthcare decisions: HIPAA means you cannot access your adult child's medical information without their authorization — even if you are their caregiver. Have them sign a healthcare proxy or HIPAA release before they turn 18.

Register to vote: Your young adult has the right to vote. Register them at 18 — it is a civil right and a powerful act of self-determination.

The Transition Cliff Checklist — Start at Age 16

Age 14-16

- ☐ Connect with Vocational Rehabilitation — early connection = more funding
- ☐ Research post-secondary options (college, vocational, supported employment)
- ☐ Begin teaching self-advocacy skills — your child should know their diagnosis and rights
- ☐ Apply for SSI at age 16 if appropriate
- ☐ Research your state's DD agency waitlist — apply now, waitlists are years long

Age 16-18

- ☐ Confirm transition services are in the IEP and being provided
- ☐ Tour post-secondary programs of interest
- ☐ Begin guardianship or supported decision-making planning
- ☐ Apply to post-secondary programs
- ☐ Connect with college disability services if applicable
- ☐ Set up healthcare proxy and HIPAA releases before 18th birthday

Age 18-21 (Final School Years)

- ☐ Request Summary of Performance document — school must provide at exit
- ☐ Obtain copies of ALL evaluations, IEPs, and educational records
- ☐ Confirm active connection with all adult service agencies
- ☐ Identify day programs, employment supports, or residential options
- ☐ Apply for Medicaid waiver if not already done
- ☐ Plan for daily structure BEFORE the last day of school



[] Celebrate — your child has earned this milestone

Adult services I have already connected with:

Waitlists I am on and application dates:

My biggest concerns about the transition:

You Are Not Alone at the Cliff

The transition out of school is hard. The system changes, the supports change, and the path forward is less clear. But families who plan — who apply early, build relationships with adult service agencies, and start talking about the future years before it arrives — land on solid ground. Ask Ada any question about transition planning at iepapproved.com. She knows the law, the resources, and the path forward.